

activities of the Bolsheviks to prevent a coup. Orders were issued for the arrest of leading party members, and their newspaper, *Pravda* (The Truth), was closed down. Lenin, keeping a low profile in his apartment, urged action. "We must not wait! We may lose everything! The government is tottering. To delay action is the same as death," he wrote.

On October 25 (November 7, GC), the government tried without success to find armed support. The Petrograd Soviet of Workers and Soldiers party, of which the Bolsheviks were a faction, could rely on the support of troops in Petrograd (later St. Petersburg). The Bolshevik paramilitary Red Guards occupied the main telegraph office, post office, and power stations. Only the Winter Palace, the seat of the government, remained. The small unit of military cadets guarding it willingly surrendered to the revolutionary soldiers. The regime was overthrown, and power had passed to Lenin and his Bolsheviks.

Laying the groundwork

The October Revolution was the culmination of the civil unrest that had rumbled on for months. On February 23, 1917 (March 8, GC), in Petrograd, a riot had started, led by women frustrated at waiting hours for bread. They marched through the city, gathering support as they went. This grew into a general strike, and the demonstrations took on a more political nature. Red flags began to appear, and statues of Czar Nicholas II were toppled. Soldiers refused to obey orders to fire on the crowd, but police shot and killed 50 people. »



Vladimir Lenin addresses his troops in Moscow's Red Square in 1919, during the civil war that followed the October Revolution.



Vladimir Ilyich Lenin

Born Vladimir Ilyich Ulyanov on April 10, 1870 (April 22, GC), the founder of the Bolsheviks and first leader of Soviet Russia was a bold theorist and tireless organizer. Lenin became an active Marxist revolutionary after his brother Alexander was executed in 1887 for conspiring to assassinate Czar Alexander III, an event that caused Lenin to lose faith in God and religion. In 1895, he was arrested and exiled for three years to Siberia.

Lenin's chief aim was to organize the opposition to the Czar into a single coherent movement. Following the Russian Revolution of March 1917, he returned to Russia believing his moment had come. In October, Lenin led the Bolsheviks against the government then, suppressing all opposition, became dictator of the world's first communist state.

Lenin's main challenge was civil war (1918–1920). The Communists won, but Russia was brought to its knees. The strain of leadership also broke his health. After two strokes, one of which deprived him of speech, he died on January 21, 1924.